

Malware

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Malicious software, or malware, is harmful programs that gain illegal access to digital devices. They can make their way into a computer or device via email attachments or unprotected websites.

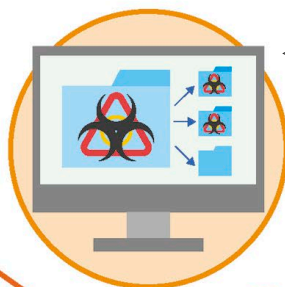
Types of malware

Malware can break into a computer and wreak havoc. These programs can slow down a device, send spam emails, or even steal or delete personal data. Malware is classified based on how it enters the computer, and what it does once it's there. Here are the different types of malware that can attack a digital device.



◀ Worms

Similar to viruses, worms tag along with legitimate downloads. They're self-replicating and can spread through networks, often via automated email spam. Unlike viruses, worms are stand-alone software. They don't need human triggers and are only installed on each computer once.

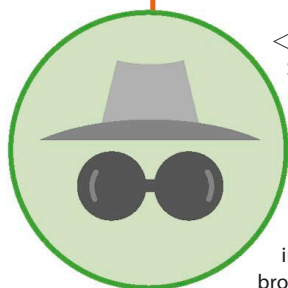
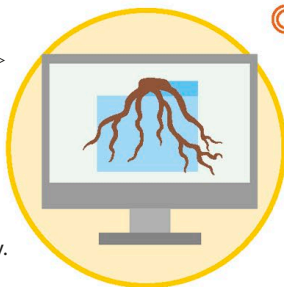


◀ Viruses

Viruses are tiny pieces of code that sneak in by attaching themselves to pre-existing files, such as email attachments. The goal of a virus is to spread to as many files on as many systems as possible. They corrupt data and slow down operating systems.

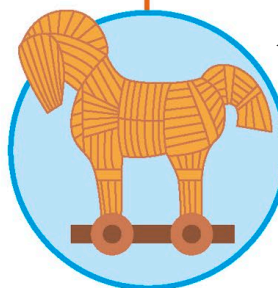
Rootkits ▶

Rootkits hide inside an operating system. They gain root (administrator) access to a computer and modify critical files, which can lower security and let in other types of malware. As they hide inside operating systems, they are difficult to detect and destroy.



◀ Spyware

Spyware is a general term for any program that tracks data without permission. Examples include keyloggers (programs that track what keys are pressed in order to gain access to passwords and other information) or programs that copy browser history and Google searches.



◀ Trojans

Named after the Greek tale of the Trojan Horse, a trojan is a malicious program that looks safe. Once downloaded, the trojan installs its payload on the computer. This could be a keylogger, a backdoor, or any number of malicious programs.

